

Notes: Duarte, Finan, Larreguy & Schechter (RES, 2026)

Brokering Votes With Information Spread Via Social Networks

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** How do social networks help political brokers target vote-buying transfers, and how does this shape broker recruitment?
- **Context.** The paper studies political brokers and citizens in rural Paraguay, where party registration and turnout are relatively observable but reciprocity is private information.
- **Main measure.** Hearing is a broker-citizen dyad measure of how often information originating from a citizen is expected to reach a broker through the village network.
- **Main result.** Hearing predicts broker knowledge, vote-buying targeting, and post-election citizen support for the broker’s party.
- **Mechanism.** Brokers use hearing to identify reciprocal non-copartisans. Copartisans are targeted regardless of reciprocity, consistent with turnout buying.
- **Recruitment.** Parties recruit brokers who are especially central among non-copartisans, not among copartisans.
- **Takeaway.** Social networks sustain vote buying by transmitting hidden social information to brokers.

2 Background, data, and measurement

2.1 Political setting

Paraguay has a strong two-party structure and a widespread role for political brokers. Brokers act as intermediaries between candidates and citizens, distributing transfers and using local knowledge to deliver votes.

Interpretation: Party registration and turnout can be observed, but reciprocity is hidden. This makes social networks important for targeting non-copartisans.

2.2 Data sources

The paper combines village network data, household surveys, broker surveys, citizen-reported political support, party registration, and experimental reciprocity from trust-game data. The main dyad sample contains 932 broker-citizen observations.

Interpretation: The data are unusually rich because they observe both the broker side and the citizen side of vote-buying decisions.

2.3 Hearing

Let g be the village adjacency matrix, p the probability of transmission across a link, and T the number of diffusion periods. Hearing is

$$H = \sum_{t=1}^T (pg)^t, \quad H_{ib} = \text{the } ib \text{ entry of } H.$$

Broker diffusion centrality is $\sum_i H_{ib}$.

Interpretation: Hearing captures all direct and indirect paths through which information about citizen i can reach broker b .

3 Conceptual framework and empirical specifications

3.1 Turnout buying versus vote buying

Turnout buying targets copartisans who support the broker's party but may not turn out. Vote buying targets non-copartisans who would otherwise support another party but may reciprocate a transfer.

Interpretation: Reciprocity matters for vote buying because the secret ballot prevents direct enforcement.

3.2 Baseline dyad regression

$$y_{ib} = \alpha + \beta H_{ib} + \theta_i + \eta_b + X'_{ib}\delta + \varepsilon_{ib}.$$

Interpretation: Citizen fixed effects control citizen traits; broker fixed effects control broker traits. Identification comes from dyad-specific variation in hearing.

3.3 Reciprocity and party-registration interactions

$$y_{ib} = \alpha + \beta_1 H_{ib} + \beta_2 R_i + \beta_3 N_{ib} + \beta_4 H_{ib} R_i + \beta_5 H_{ib} N_{ib} + \beta_6 R_i N_{ib} + \beta_7 H_{ib} R_i N_{ib} + \theta_i + \eta_b + \varepsilon_{ib}.$$

Here R_i is reciprocity and N_{ib} indicates that citizen i is not registered to broker b 's party.

Interpretation: The key prediction is $\beta_7 > 0$.

3.4 Broker recruitment

$$y_{iv} = \alpha + \beta Broker_{iv} + \gamma DirectlySurveyed_{iv} + \eta_v + \varepsilon_{iv}.$$

Interpretation: This tests whether broker households are more central, especially among non-copartisans.

4 Identification and empirical design

The main challenge is that network links are not randomly assigned. The design uses broker and citizen fixed effects to compare dyad-specific hearing across the same brokers and citizens. Robustness checks control for direct links, social distance, support pairs, transaction ties, strategic interactions, and incomplete network sampling. The design does not prove random network formation, but the results follow sharply from the theoretical predictions.

5 Section-by-section study guide

- **Introduction:** explains why secret ballots do not eliminate vote buying.
- **Background:** describes brokers and political parties in Paraguay.
- **Conceptual framework:** derives predictions about hearing, reciprocity, and broker centrality.

- **Data:** explains the network, vote-buying, reciprocity, and party-registration measures.
- **Empirical strategy:** presents dyad fixed-effects regressions and broker recruitment regressions.
- **Results:** tests knowledge, targeting, mechanism, robustness, and recruitment.

6 Tables and figures

6.1 Figure 1: Illustration of the computation of hearing between citizen i and broker b

Read: The figure shows information originating from citizen i and moving through the network. Broker b first has a positive chance of hearing the information after the relevant paths reach him.

Detailed interpretation: Hearing differs from social distance because it counts all paths and repeated diffusion, not just the shortest path.

Economic message: Brokers are valuable because they receive network-transmitted gossip and reputational information.

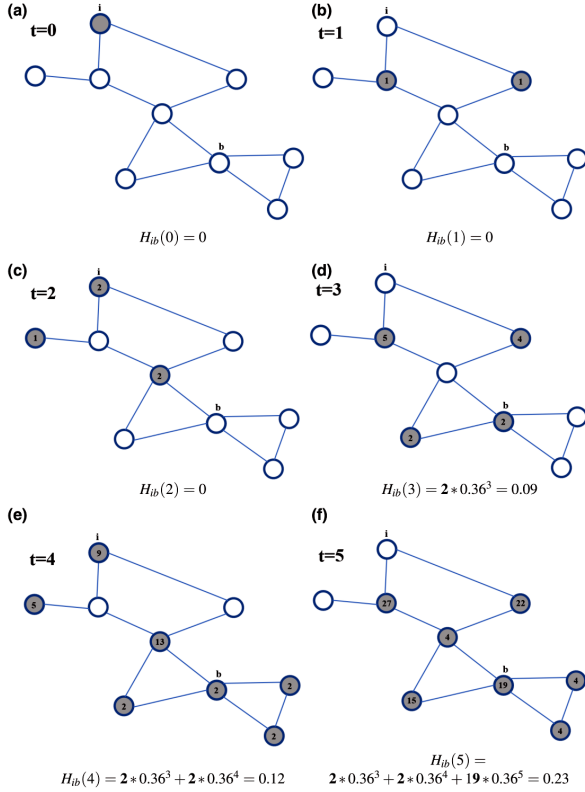


FIGURE 1
Illustration of the computation of *hearing* between citizen i and broker b . (a) $H_{ib}(0) = 0$, (b) $H_{ib}(1) = 0$, (c) $H_{ib}(2) = 0$, (d) $H_{ib}(3) = 2 * 0.36^3 = 0.09$, (e) $H_{ib}(4) = 2 * 0.36^3 + 2 * 0.36^4 = 0.12$, (f) $H_{ib}(5) = 2 * 0.36^3 + 2 * 0.36^4 + 19 * 0.36^5 = 0.23$.
Notes: $H_{ib}(t)$ is *hearing* between citizen i and broker b in period t . We set $p = 0.36$ (the inverse of the largest eigenvalue of the adjacency matrix). Numbers in nodes indicate the maximum number of times information about citizen i might have been transmitted to that node that period.

TABLE 1
Summary statistics

	Observations	Mean	Median	Standard deviation
Non-standardized network measures				
<i>Hearing</i>	932	0.120	0.077	0.128
Social distance	932	2.442	2	1.071
Citizen's degree centrality	295	8.875	8	4.508
Citizen's clustering coefficient	295	0.255	0.222	0.190
Citizen's betweenness centrality	295	0.044	0.031	0.049
Citizen's eigenvector centrality	295	0.122	0.110	0.082
Citizen's diffusion centrality	295	8.742	8.328	5.302
Citizen's diffusion centrality among copartisans	245	3.093	2.417	2.536
Citizen's diffusion centrality among non-copartisans	245	2.556	1.825	2.476
Absolute difference in degree centrality	932	4.921	4	4.141
Absolute difference in clustering coefficient	932	0.202	0.118	0.223
Absolute difference in betweenness centrality	932	0.042	0.028	0.046
Absolute difference in eigenvector centrality	932	0.081	0.073	0.061
Absolute difference in diffusion centrality	932	5.456	4.807	4.279
Existence of a support pair	932	0.529	1	0.499
Number of support pairs	932	1.351	1	1.852
Transaction tie	932	0.128	0	0.334
Mediating measures				
Experimental reciprocity	85	0.044	0	0.076
Not registered to the broker's party	932	0.568	1	0.496
Additional controls				
Absolute age difference	932	16	14	12
Broker and citizen have the same gender	932	0.580	1	0.494
Distance in kilometres between the broker's and citizen's residences	932	1.409	1.203	0.901
Vote-buying outcome measures				
Citizen supports the broker's party	932	0.461	0	0.499
Components of the vote-buying targeting index				
Broker approached citizen during electoral campaign	932	0.477	0	0.500
Broker offered citizen something	932	0.273	0	0.446
Knowledge outcome measures				
Components of the covariates index				
Broker knows citizen	932	0.887	1	0.316
Broker knows citizen's spouse	932	0.773	1	0.419
Broker knows citizen's years of education	932	0.807	1	0.395
Broker knows citizen's amount of land	932	0.421	0	0.494
Components of the political index				
Broker knows strength of citizen's party preference	932	0.593	1	0.491
Components of the social preferences index				
Broker knows the frequency with which citizen would retaliate	932	0.586	1	0.493
Broker knows whether the citizen generally trusts others in the village	932	0.656	1	0.475

6.2 Table 1: Summary statistics

Read: The dyad sample has 932 observations. Hearing has mean 0.120 and median 0.077. Brokers approach 47.7% of citizens and offer something to 27.3%.

Detailed interpretation: The variation in hearing and targeting motivates dyad-level analysis.

Economic message: Vote buying is selective, and network information helps explain who is selected.

6.3 Table 2: Relationship between hearing and brokers' knowledge about citizens and vote-buying targeting

Read: Hearing predicts broker knowledge, vote-buying targeting, broker offers, broker approaches, and citizen support for the broker's party.

Detailed interpretation: This is the core reduced-form table: the same network measure predicts information acquisition and political targeting.

Economic message: Network information is used in political exchange.

TABLE 2
Relationship between hearing and brokers' knowledge about citizens and vote-buying targeting

	Overall knowledge index		Covariates index	Political index	Social preferences index
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Panel A: Brokers' knowledge about citizens					
Hearing	0.286*** (0.0416)	0.211*** (0.0355)	0.170*** (0.0411)	0.197*** (0.0714)	0.140*** (0.0442)
Mean of dependent variable	-0.0000	-0.0000	0.0000	-0.0000	0.0000
Broker FE	X	X	X	X	X
Citizen FE		X	X	X	X
Observations	932	932	932	932	932
R ²	0.1546	0.6395	0.6237	0.5562	0.6962

(continued)

(a) Panel A: knowledge

TABLE 2
Continued

	Vote-buying targeting index		Broker offered citizen	Broker approached citizen	Support the same party
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
el B: Brokers' vote-buying targeting					
Hearing	0.2114*** (0.0436)	0.3215*** (0.0574)	0.0720** (0.0270)	0.1833*** (0.0399)	0.1174*** (0.0388)
Mean of dependent variable	-0.0000	-0.0000	0.2725	0.4775	0.4614
Broker FE	X	X	X	X	X
Citizen FE		X	X	X	X
Observations	932	932	932	932	932
χ ²	0.3983	0.6129	0.6688	0.5181	0.4167

Notes: All specifications include broker fixed effects. The dependent variables in Panel A are standardized indices (with mean 0 and standard deviation of 1) that aggregate what the broker knows about the citizen. The covariates index aggregates indicators for whether the broker knows the citizen, whether the broker knows the citizen's spouse's name, whether the broker knows how much land the citizen owns, and whether the broker knows the citizen's years of education. The political index corresponds to an indicator for whether the broker knows the right of the citizen's party preference. The social preferences index aggregates indicators for whether the broker knows whether the citizen generally trusts others in the village, and whether the broker knows the frequency with which the citizen would retaliate wrongdoing. The overall knowledge index aggregates indicators from all three knowledge categories. The vote-buying targeting index is a standardized sum of indicators for whether the broker offered the citizen something during the electoral campaign and whether the broker approached the citizen to talk about the electoral campaign. "Support the same party" is an indicator that the citizen claims to support the broker's party shortly after the election. Hearing is standardized. robust errors use two-way clustering at the broker and citizen levels. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding p-values are less than 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

(b) Panel B: targeting

6.4 Table 3: Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, testing for strategic interactions

Read: Own hearing remains positive after accounting for other brokers' hearing and targeting.

Detailed interpretation: The result addresses the concern that brokers are merely copying or avoiding other brokers.

Economic message: Individual brokers use their own information channels.

TABLE 3
Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, testing for strategic interactions

	Vote-buying targeting index	
	(1)	(2)
<i>Hearing</i>	0.4149*** (0.1036)	0.0642** (0.0252)
Mean same-party brokers' <i>hearing</i>	0.1499* (0.0748)	
Mean same-party brokers' targeting		-0.6736*** (0.0660)
Mean other-party brokers' <i>hearing</i>	0.0606 (0.1291)	
Mean other-party brokers' targeting		-1.2420*** (0.0777)
Mean of dependent variable	-0.0000	-0.0000
Observations	932	932
R ²	0.6218	0.9268

Notes: All specifications include broker and citizen fixed effects. The vote-buying targeting index is a standardized index (with mean 0 and standard deviation of 1) that takes the sum of indicators for whether the broker offered the citizen something during the electoral campaign and whether the broker approached the citizen to talk about the electoral campaign. *Hearing* is standardized. "Mean same-party brokers' *hearing* (targeting)" represents the standardized average value of *hearing* (the vote-buying targeting index) of other brokers from the same party with the same citizen. "Mean other-party brokers' *hearing* (targeting)" represents the standardized average value of *hearing* (the vote-buying targeting index) of brokers from another party with the same citizen. In case there is no data on same-party or other-party brokers, either because there is no such broker or because we don't have their data, we set mean *hearing* and targeting to zero and include indicators for those cases as controls. Standard errors use two-way clustering at the broker and citizen levels. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding *p*-values are less than 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

6.5 Table 4: Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, robustness tests for network endogeneity

Read: Hearing remains positive after controls for direct links, social distance, support pairs, transaction ties, and modified network definitions.

Detailed interpretation: The table supports the interpretation that hearing is not merely direct friendship or financial connectedness.

Economic message: Information diffusion is the relevant network channel.

6.6 Table 5: Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, sequentially dropping least partially sampled villages

Read: The hearing coefficient stays positive and often increases when villages with lower network sampling rates are dropped.

Detailed interpretation: Missing network data likely attenuate the estimates rather than creating them.

Economic message: The main effect appears robust to incomplete network measurement.

TABLE 4
Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, with robustness tests for network endogeneity

	Vote-buying targeting index									
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
<i>Hearing</i>	0.3127*** (0.0758)	0.2085* (0.1218)	0.2456** (0.1180)	0.2976*** (0.0749)	0.2590* (0.1298)	0.3656*** (0.0740)	0.3709*** (0.0767)	0.3991*** (0.0425)	0.3092*** (0.0773)	0.3318** (0.1517)
Direct link between broker and citizen		0.2224 (0.2001)								
Social distance				-0.0275 (0.0669)						-0.0234 (0.0883)
Number of support pairs						-0.0761 (0.0853)				-0.0096 (0.1049)
Transaction tie								0.0349 (0.1399)		-0.1434 (0.1929)
Mean of dependent variable	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000	-0.0000
Broker-citizen controls	X									X
Instrumenting for <i>hearing</i>			X							
Social distance controls					X					
Support pair controls							X			
Excluding transaction ties								X		
Observations	932	932	932	932	932	932	932	932	932	932
R ²	0.7335	0.6140		0.6130	0.6168	0.6135	0.6195	0.6095	0.6129	0.7345

Notes: All specifications include broker and citizen fixed effects. The dependent variable is a standardized index (with mean 0 and standard deviation of 1) that takes the sum of indicators for whether the broker offered the citizen something during the electoral campaign and whether the broker approached the citizen to talk about the electoral campaign. Columns (1) and (10) control for broker-citizen controls: (1) an indicator for the broker and citizen having the same gender; (2) an indicator for the citizen being registered to the broker's party; (3) standardized geographical distance between the broker's and citizen's residences; (4) standardized absolute difference in age, degree centrality, clustering coefficient, betweenness centrality, diffusion centrality, and eigenvector centrality; and (5) broker fixed effects interacted with citizen's degree centrality, clustering coefficient, betweenness centrality, diffusion centrality, and eigenvector centrality. "Direct link between broker and citizen" is an indicator for observations which are directly linked. In Column (3), we instrument for the original *hearing* measure with one that excludes information flows from directly connected citizen-broker dyads. We do not show the R² for the instrumental variable regression in Column (3). Social distance controls include indicators for each value of social distance. Support pair controls include indicators for each value of the number of support pairs. All network measures (except the indicator variables) are standardized. Standard errors use two-way clustering at the broker and citizen levels. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding *p*-values are less than 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

TABLE 5
Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, by party registration and experimental reciprocity

	Vote-buying targeting index							
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
<i>Hearing</i>	0.2275*** (0.0597)	0.2257*** (0.0850)	0.2281*** (0.0550)	0.2641** (0.1059)	0.1179* (0.0662)	0.1221 (0.0860)	0.1155* (0.0611)	0.1407* (0.0797)
Experimental reciprocity				-0.0595 (0.0659)				0.1300 (0.1462)
Not reg. to broker's party					-0.6944*** (0.1314)	-0.8182*** (0.1735)	-0.7192*** (0.1410)	-0.8451*** (0.1809)
Experimental reciprocity × <i>Hearing</i>				0.1346** (0.0653)	0.1243 (0.1417)		-0.1707 (0.1710)	-0.2424 (0.2283)
Experimental reciprocity × Not reg. to broker's party						0.0949 (0.0972)	0.1026 (0.1326)	0.1028 (0.0925)
Not reg. to broker's party × <i>Hearing</i>								0.2674** (0.1089)
Not reg. to broker's party × <i>Hearing</i> × Experimental reciprocity								0.2775* (0.1531)
Mean of dependent variable	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000
Broker FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Citizen FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Observations	271	271	271	271	271	271	271	271
R ²	0.4839	0.6253	0.5002	0.6310	0.5769	0.6984	0.5995	0.7153

Notes: All specifications include broker and citizen fixed effects. The dependent variable is a standardized index (with mean 0 and standard deviation of 1) that takes the sum of indicators for whether the broker offered the citizen something during the electoral campaign and whether the broker approached the citizen to talk about the electoral campaign. "Not reg. to broker's party" indicates the citizen is not officially registered to the broker's party. "Experimental reciprocity" is the experimental measure of reciprocity used in Fisman and Schecter (2012). The coefficients for experimental reciprocity in Columns (4) and (8) are absorbed by the citizen fixed effects. *Hearing* and experimental reciprocity are standardized. Standard errors use two-way clustering at the broker and citizen levels. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding *p*-values are less than 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

6.7 Table 6: Relationship between hearing and vote-buying targeting, by party registration and experimental reciprocity

Read: The triple interaction of hearing, reciprocity, and non-copartisanship is positive.

Detailed interpretation: Brokers target reciprocal non-copartisans when they can learn about their reciprocity through the network.

Economic message: The hidden trait revealed by networks is reciprocity, and it matters where vote buying requires reciprocal behaviour.

6.8 Table 7: Relationship between hearing and citizen support for the broker's party, by party registration and experimental reciprocity

Read: The triple interaction is also positive for citizen support for the broker's party.

Detailed interpretation: The support outcome validates the broker-reported targeting mechanism.

Economic message: Network-informed targeting translates into political support.

TABLE 7
Relationship between hearing and citizen support for the broker's party, by party registration and experimental reciprocity

	Support same party						
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
Hearing	0.1260*** (0.0349)	0.1770** (0.0695)	0.1322*** (0.0330)	0.1737** (0.0714)	0.0493 (0.0496)	0.0413 (0.0516)	0.0408 (0.0362)
Experimental reciprocity			-0.0620 (0.0396)				0.0779** (0.0357)
Not reg. to broker's party					-0.6324*** (0.0712)	-0.8742*** (0.0732)	-0.8824*** (0.0375)
Experimental reciprocity × Hearing			0.0681* (0.0359)	0.0453 (0.0544)			-0.0175 (0.0715)
Experimental reciprocity × Not reg. to broker's party							-0.1892 (0.0296)
Not reg. to broker's party × Hearing					0.0444 (0.0556)	-0.0439 (0.0608)	-0.0389 (0.0589)
Not reg. to broker's party × Hearing × Experimental reciprocity						0.0817* (0.0447)	0.0871*** (0.0314)
Mean of dependent variable	0.4280	0.4280	0.4280	0.4280	0.4280	0.4280	0.4280
Broker FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Citizen FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Observations	271	271	271	271	271	271	271
R ²	0.2408	0.4464	0.3645	0.4495	0.5482	0.7773	0.5617

Notes: All specifications include broker fixed effects. The dependent variable is an indicator that the citizen claims to support the broker's party shortly after the election. "Not reg. to broker's party" indicates the citizen is not officially registered to the broker's party. "Experimental reciprocity" is the experimental measure of reciprocity used in [Fisman and Schecter \(2012\)](#). The coefficients for experimental reciprocity in Columns (4) and (6) are absorbed by the citizen fixed effects. Hearing and experimental reciprocity are standardized. Standard errors use two-way clustering at the broker and citizen levels. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding p-values are < 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

TABLE 8
Brokers' differential relative position within their village social network

	Betweenness centrality (1)	Eigenvector centrality (2)	Diffusion centrality		Degree centrality	
			Overall (3)	Among copartisans (4)	Among non-copartisans (5)	Overall (6)
						Among copartisans (7)
						Among non-copartisans (8)
Panel A: Overall standardized centrality measures						
Broker	0.1046 (0.1538)	0.6021*** (0.1428)	0.5739*** (0.1457)	-0.1868 (0.1740)	2.1281*** (0.1644)	0.3844*** (0.1233)
Mean of dependent variable	-0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	0.0000	-0.0000
R ²	0.2850	0.3840	0.3581	0.5096	0.5618	0.5406
Panel B: Within-village percentiles of centrality measures						
Broker	7.828*** (3.6530)	21.4197*** (4.6490)	19.8667*** (4.4525)	-3.2561 (7.1397)	39.0104*** (6.5212)	13.6667*** (3.5972)
Mean of dependent variable	50.0964	50.0160	49.9884	48.6286	48.6286	49.9816
Village FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Directly surveyed FE	X	X	X	X	X	X
Observations	1,032	1,032	1,032	245	245	1,032
R ²	0.4722	0.2173	0.2627	0.0090	0.1733	0.4998

Notes: All specifications include village fixed effects and control for whether the household was surveyed directly about their network ties. Sample for Columns (1) to (3) and (6) includes all households directly and indirectly sampled. Columns (4), (5), (7), and (8) include all households for which we have party registration data. Column (3) presents diffusion centrality (the sum of hearing) across all households. Column (4) presents diffusion centrality only among copartisans of the household, and Column (5) presents diffusion centrality only among non-copartisans of the household. Column (6) presents degree centrality across all households. Column (7) presents degree centrality only among copartisans of the household, and Column (8) presents degree centrality only among non-copartisans of the household. Copartisanship is determined by whether individuals were registered to the same party. The dependent variables in Panel A are standardized (mean 0, s.d. 1), while those in Panel B are the within-village percentiles (ranging from 1 to 100) for each corresponding outcome. *, **, and *** indicate that the corresponding p-values are less than 10%, 5%, and 1%, respectively.

6.9 Table 8: Brokers' differential relative position within their village social network

Read: Brokers are more central overall and especially more central among non-copartisans. They are not more central among copartisans.

Detailed interpretation: Parties recruit brokers whose network position helps them learn about non-copartisans.

Economic message: Broker recruitment is part of the information technology of vote buying.

7 Result map

- Hearing predicts broker knowledge: Table 2 Panel A.

- Hearing predicts targeting and party support: Table 2 Panel B.
- Strategic interactions do not explain the effect: Table 3.
- Network endogeneity robustness supports the mechanism: Table 4.
- Incomplete network sampling likely attenuates estimates: Table 5.
- Reciprocity matters for non-copartisans: Table 6.
- The same mechanism predicts citizen support: Table 7.
- Broker recruitment matches the model: Table 8.

8 Short summary

Social networks enable brokers to learn hidden politically relevant traits. Hearing predicts knowledge, targeting, and citizen support. The strongest mechanism is among reciprocal non-copartisans, and parties recruit brokers who are central among non-copartisans.

9 Conclusion

9.1 Core conclusion

Social networks sustain vote buying by transmitting hidden information from citizens to brokers.

9.2 Economic intuition

Vote buying under a secret ballot requires trust or reciprocity. Brokers use social networks to identify citizens likely to reciprocate transfers.

9.3 Why the evidence is persuasive

The evidence combines broker and citizen fixed effects, multiple outcomes, mechanism tests, robustness checks, and broker recruitment patterns.

9.4 Policy implications

Interventions that reduce the political use of social information could weaken vote buying, but social networks also provide valuable informal insurance and learning benefits.

9.5 Limitations

Network links are not randomly assigned, reciprocity is observed only for a smaller sample, and the setting is most directly applicable where party registration and turnout are observable.

9.6 Final takeaway

Political brokers are network-positioned information aggregators. The paper shows how social information makes clientelistic exchange feasible.